

A near-fatal knife attack in Belfast, and the question it forced on the Commons

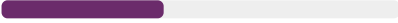
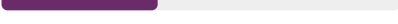
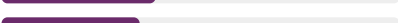
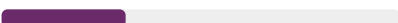
8 divisions 2,161 written questions 251 distinct askers

A man in his forties is fighting life-threatening injuries in a Belfast hospital after a knife was held to his throat in the street on Monday night. Three passers-by ran in to stop the attack. Within a day it had become a political emergency. There was serious disorder across the city, a flood of claims true and false, and an Urgent Question that put the Northern Ireland Secretary on the spot over immigration and the border. Immigration and the border are close to the only part of this Westminster can answer for. It was the gravest story of the week. It was also a week in which Members of Parliament voted eight times, six of them on steel.

THE DIVISIONS, CLOSEST FIRST

Steel Industry (Nationalisation) Bill...		145–251
Steel Industry (Nationalisation) Bill...		157–287
Agriculture (Delinked Payments) (...)		302–155
Steel Industry (Nationalisation) Bill, ...		81–266
Steel Industry (Nationalisation) Bill, ...		65–251
Steel Industry (Nationalisation) Bill, ...		90–290
Steel Industry (Nationalisation) Bill, ...		94–297
Combined Authorities (Mayoral Ele...		356–86

WRITTEN QUESTIONS, BY DEPARTMENT

Health		320
Transport		218
Home Office		172
Environment		159
Housing		158
Defence		155
Treasury		130
Business and Trade		125
Cabinet Office		123
Education		110
Energy		100
Work and Pensions		91
14 others		300

THE MOST-ASKED SUBJECTS

10 HM Coastguard: Conditions of Employment 10 Lord Mandelson 8 Prostate Cancer: Screening
 7 Electric Vehicles: Charging Points 7 Police: Equality 7 Construction: Training 6 Members: Correspondence
 5 Agriculture: UK Trade with EU 5 Tyres: Waste Disposal 5 Youth Diversion Orders

A SAMPLE OF THE WEEK'S QUESTIONS

Immigration · Mike Martin, Liberal Democrat

When does the Department plan to respond to the Earned Settlement consultation that closed on 12 February 2026?

THE ANSWER The earned settlement model, proposed in 'A Fairer Pathway to Settlement', was subject to a public consultation which opened on 20 November 2025 and closed on 12 February 2026. We received over 200,000 responses and are now in the process of carefully considering the feedback received.

Dental Services: Finance · Martin Wrigley, Liberal Democrat

Will NHS dentistry funding keep pace with inflation and population growth across the current Spending Review period?

THE ANSWER The 2025 Spending Review sets departmental budgets for day-to-day spending up to 2028/29 and for capital for five years to 2029/30. The Government wants to ensure that every penny we allocate for dentistry is spent on dentistry, and that the ringfenced dental budget is spent on the patients who need it most.

Agriculture: UK Trade with EU · Tim Farron, Liberal Democrat

What estimate has the Department made of the number of small and medium-sized enterprises that may need to change production processes, certification, labelling or IT systems under the new UK–EU agreement?

THE ANSWER The precise impacts of the agreement will depend on the outcome of the negotiations. As technical negotiations progress, this Government expects to follow normal processes for any necessary legislative changes and assess impacts accordingly, and will work with businesses to ensure a smooth transition.

FEATURE

The Urgent Question, and the answer the Secretary of State couldn't give

Policing and justice are devolved to Stormont and the Police Service of Northern Ireland, so Westminster's hold on the Belfast attack is narrow. That is why the Commons' set-piece on it, an Urgent Question from the Democratic Unionist Party's Gavin Robinson, turned on the reserved questions of immigration, asylum and the border rather than the investigation itself. (The charge is attempted murder. The victim, a man in his forties, is fighting life-threatening injuries and has not been named.) Robinson pressed on the suspect's reported five-year visa and on community cohesion.